

AMERICA'S SCHOOL TRUST LIBRARY

For Teachers

A card from America's School Trust Library

AN INVITATION · VERSION 1 · SEPTEMBER 2026 · SCHOOLTRUSTS.ORG

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WHAT THIS LIBRARY IS

America's School Trust Library is an Oregon nonprofit public benefit corporation, Oregon Registry No. 259005891, formed in July 2026. It collects, verifies and publishes the record of the school trust lands the United States granted to the states at statehood — what was granted, what was promised, what happened to it, and what the courts have said about it. Beginning in 1785, Congress set aside land in every township — the six-mile survey square the country was laid out in — to support the public schools; roughly twenty states still hold those lands and their funds today. The Library publishes in the open, corrects in public, and keeps a numbered corrections ledger anyone can read. Everything is free: no fee, no account, no affiliation. It takes no side in any case or campaign.

It is not asking you for money. It asks for documents and hands.

schooltrusts.org

The oldest school-funding decision in American history is a shape on a map

And it is probably within a few miles of your classroom.

In 1785, two years before the Constitutional Convention, Congress directed that the western lands be surveyed into townships six miles square, and that Section 16 of every township be reserved for the support of public schools within it. A township is a survey unit, not a town: a square six miles on a side, divided into thirty-six sections of one square mile each, 640 acres apiece, numbered back and forth beginning at the northeast corner. Section 16 sits near the middle. As the surveys moved into drier country, where one section no longer raised what a school needed, Congress doubled the grant and added Section 36, at the southeast corner.

Two years after that, the Northwest Ordinance put the reason in a sentence that ends "... schools and the means of education shall forever be encouraged" (Northwest Ordinance, 1787, Article 3). It is easy to quote and hard to enforce, which is most of the history of the school lands in one line.

The corners are still findable — posts, stone mounds, later brass caps, in hayfields and road ditches. The grid is the deed. That is a lesson you can walk to.

WHAT THE LIBRARY CAN PUT IN FRONT OF A CLASS

Primary sources, free, with no account required: the granting act in the federal statute book; your state's own constitutional clause accepting the trust; land patents, which record the moment a piece of ground leaves the public domain; fund reports; maps; photographs of the schools the sections were for. Each is shown with where it came from, and what the Library has not verified is marked as not verified.

For older students the more interesting object may be the corrections ledger — a numbered public list of things this institution published and then got wrong. It is a better lesson about evidence than most textbooks manage, because the errors are real and the fixes are dated.

WHAT THE LIBRARY HAS NOT BUILT

There are no lesson plans yet. That is deliberate rather than accidental: the Library would rather build a teaching set with teachers than for them, and it has not yet found the teachers. A first set — one state, one packet of primary sources, aligned to that state's social-studies standards — is exactly the kind of thing a first teacher could shape.

There is also no student program yet, and none will be improvised. Work by young people needs a supervision design of its own, and the Library will write that before it invites anyone's students in.

What a teacher can give back

A finding. A class that checks one figure on its own state's page against the state's own report is

doing verification work. If the class finds an error, a free Library Card opens the correction form — or you can simply write to the Library — and the correction goes into the public ledger with the sender credited.

Local records. School-district minutes, a school's own history, a photograph of the schoolhouse the section paid for, the file in the district office nobody has opened since the move. Attics matter as much as archives. If you are not sure whether something belongs, describe it rather than send it, and the Library will tell you.

The story itself. The 1785 story is not taught in most places, and the people best positioned to teach it are already standing in the room.

A packet, built with you. If you would want a primary-source packet for your state, say what it would have to contain to be usable on a Monday morning. That answer is the thing the Library is missing.

How to say yes

Write two paragraphs to the Library at library@schooltrusts.net, addressed to the Secretary, Kenneth Magee.

In the first, say what you teach and where. In the second, say what you would want a packet to contain, or what you have found that the Library should hold.

If you would rather just use the shelves, use them. They are open at schooltrusts.org, free, permanently, and reading asks for no account and no obligation of any kind. Start with your own state's file at schooltrusts.org/states/, or with the Map Room at [/maps/](http://schooltrusts.org/maps/).

A free Library Card is an email address, a one-time login link, no password and no fee. Reading needs none. The correction form asks you to sign in with one, so that a librarian can write back — and if you would rather not open one, write to the Library instead.

ONE HONEST LIMIT

The Library has not yet filed its application for federal tax-exempt recognition; it is being prepared. No federal tax-exemption determination has been issued, and until one is, the Library does not describe contributions as tax-deductible.

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public benefit corporation · Oregon Registry No. 259005891
· Oregon DOJ Charitable Activities Registration No. 72571 ·
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Drafted with an AI system for the Library's board, from the
Library's own record, and checked against that record by
people. Version 1, September 2026.

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